

NAME OF GOD
Kabirpanthi pilgrims inside the core zone of Bandhavgarh, Madhya Pradesh

SATYENDRA TIWARI

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

FAITH VERSUS CONSERVATION

It's faith vs conservation, as pilgrim throngs inside tiger reserves begin to pose a threat to the ecology

By **Rahul Noronha**

THE OLD INDIAN EPICS HAD DIVINITIES streaming into forest land fairly regularly, but it's not a plot device you would have expected to reappear in contemporary times. Yet, Madhya Pradesh's famed tiger reserves are where the saints go marching in today. The phenomenon has turned them into sites of a new conflict—between faith and conservation. Actually, it's the scale that's new. Most of the nine tiger reserves in the state happen to enclose within their jungles some old sacred sites: points of religious or community reverence. And these hubs are registering a perilous increase in pilgrim footfalls every year. So much so that the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has asked the state government to formulate a policy to regulate public movement in tiger reserves.

Takeaways

- **Most of Madhya Pradesh's nine tiger reserves have old pilgrimage sites inside**
- **Satpura's Naag mela saw 600,000 devouts in August, littering the reserve**
- **The Kabirpanthi sect's shrine inside Bandhavgarh attracted 14,000 last year**
- **With increasing footfalls, the NGT asks state govt. to regulate human movement**

The hotspots, where the pilgrim rush is so high that it warrants some form of intervention, are Bandhavgarh and Satpura. The Bandhavgarh Fort, located in the tiger reserve's core area, has a shrine revered by the Kabirpanthi community. Traditionally, they travel to the site, dedicated to the mystic poet Kabir, for *parikrama* once a year, in the last week of December. Park authorities give them permission to walk to the shrine from the Tala gate on the special day. The walk is through prime tiger country and crisscrosses the Chakradhara meadow. Over the years, though, the pilgrim footfalls have swelled. In December 2024, an estimated 14,000 came visiting.

SAGES IN THE WOOD

The Kabirpanthi sect, largely listed as a Scheduled Caste grouping, resides in large numbers along the MP-Chhattisgarh border. They form a prominent electoral group in the Vidhan Sabha seats located on that flank. Past attempts to regulate their entry have led to clashes between park authorities and pilgrims. Besides the one-day darshan, the group also stays at Tala, the entry